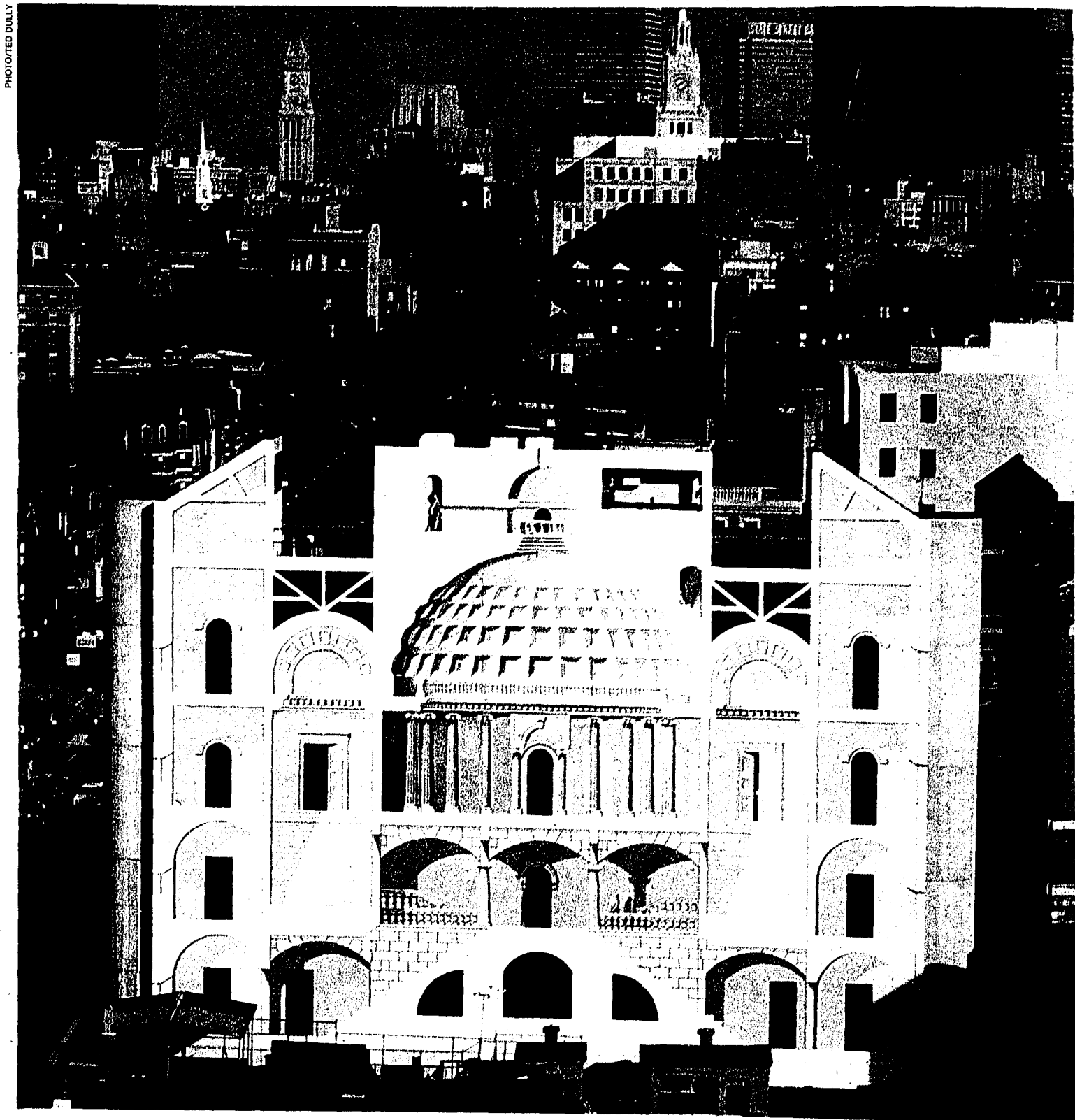


A faceless, dull wall of the Boston Architectural Center on Newbury street is transformed into the illusion of a neoclassical palace in the midst of 20th Century Boston.



PHOTO/ TED DULLY

Old faces on new places

By Robert Campbell

Frank Lloyd Wright said it: Doctors can bury their mistakes, but architects can only plant vines.

The master would be proud if he were still around to see how Boston's only school of architecture has grappled with a garish blunder that defaced its own home.

The blunder was a blank, five-story wall that was not supposed to be visible but was, alas, only too grimly apparent, looming menacingly like a Cubist Cyclops over huddled, brickly Newbury street. Instead of vines, the Boston Architectural Center has just finished covering the wall with a spectacular 50-by-85-foot mural designed by Richard Haas of New York.

Robert Campbell is The Globe's architecture writer.

Now that the paint has dried, it's turning out that the forgotten wall is this building's prettiest face.

Haas's mural is a kind of madman's fantasy of an 1800-vintage French neo-classic palace, rendered in the elaborate, shadowed cut-away drawing style made famous by another architecture school, the Ecole des Beaux Arts in Paris. A grand wing stair, domes, porticoes, arches and long, rather alarming corridors are fitted into the jagged outline of the existing wall as neatly as mosaic. A muted color scheme recalls the center's warm concrete tones and saves the mural from upstaging the building.

Bringing artist Haas to Boston was the idea of Peter Blake, the B.A.C.'s director, who helped found a group in New York called City Walls to sponsor murals by artists there. Haas achieved a kind of fame when he painted an elaborate fake cast-iron facade, complete with shadows, on the blank side of a

cast-iron-front building in SoHo. He went on to other trompe l'oeil ("fool-the-eye") projects; he also teaches art at Bennington College in Vermont.

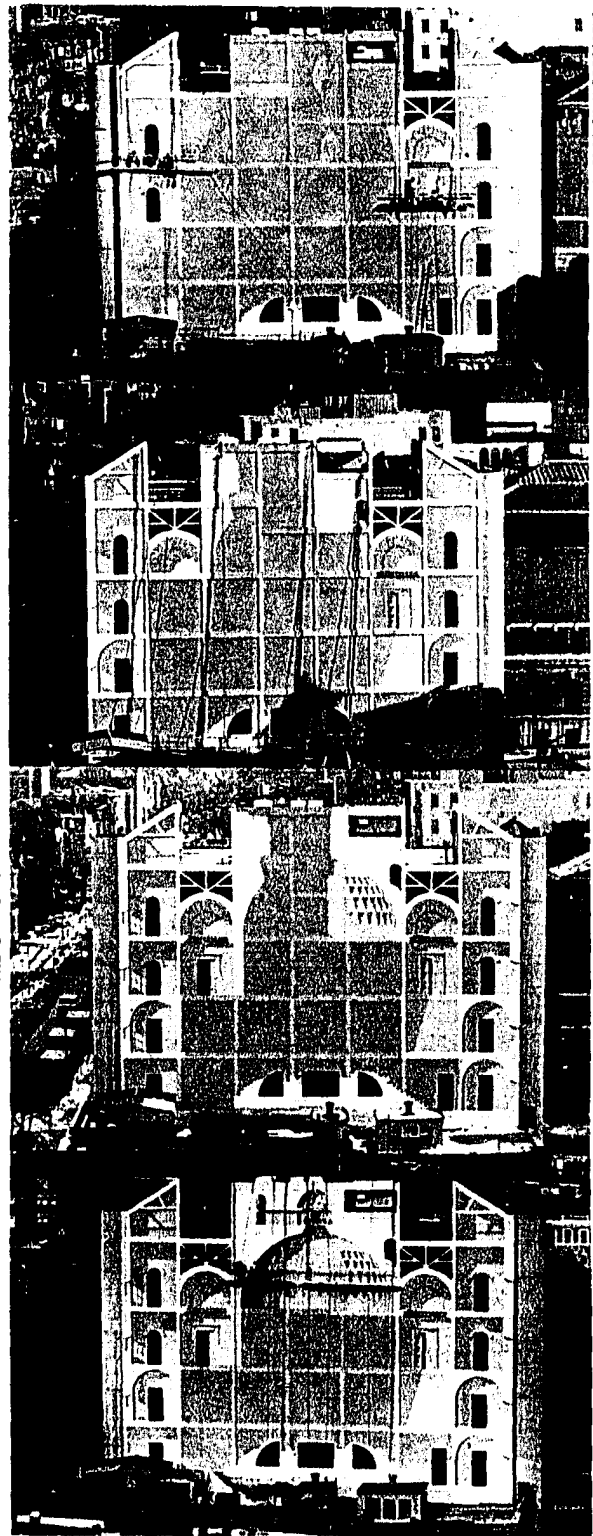
When Haas first saw the B.A.C., which is a rather severe box of interlocking concrete pieces, he said he thought it looked like "Boston Brutal Style." He started with doodles that carried this same style around onto the wall, but quickly decided that what the building needed was contrast, not imitation, and switched to the final mock-heroic design. He credits the visionary 18th Century neo-classicists Boullée and Ledoux as models.

The reason the wall was blank is that all the building's intestines are behind it — things that don't need windows: stairs, bathrooms, elevators. When the B.A.C. was designed by Ashley-Myer Associates (now Arrowstreet Inc.), who won an 89-firm competition, everyone as-

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Artist Richard Haas, designer of the mammoth mural.



PHOTOS/STAN GROSSFELD

PHOTO/IRA BERGER

Four stages of the work in progress.



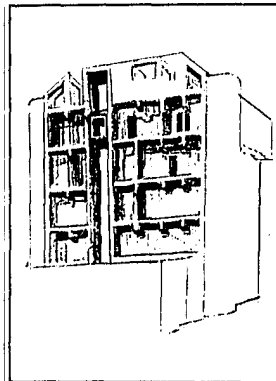
The artistry continues . . .

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 sumed that the wall would soon be invisible because the rest of the Newbury street block would soon be rebuilt to a similar height. But Boston's redevelopment boom slowed and nothing was built; with zoning changes, nothing is likely to be.

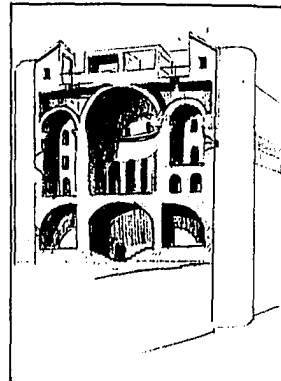
Many people have mixed feelings about the B.A.C. building — handsome, maybe, but not Back Bay — yet everyone seems to like the mural. Part of its interest is that it's only the latest in a growing gallery of such murals. Murals began flowering in Boston in the late 1960s because street widenings and demolitions had left so many sawed-off buildings and meaningless walls. Older works by black artists like Roy Cato and Dana Chandler are well known. Cambridge's fine fireman mural in Inman Square and streetscape mural behind the Star Market in Porter Square are other recent examples.

In a way, every amputated trunk of a building, every blank wall exposed by demolition, is a wound in the environment. And every mural is a bandage, a sewing together

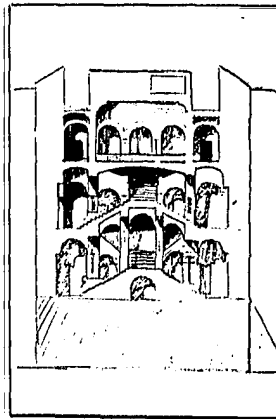
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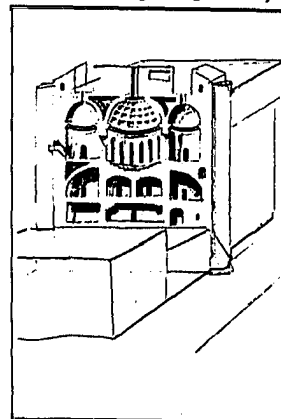
A rejected idea.



The final design begins to jell.



Early sketches with continuing refinements.



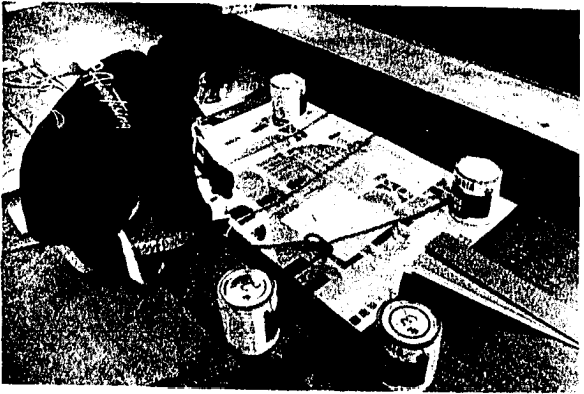
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er. As there get to be more of them, they seem to signal to each other across the intervening city as flags do when ships pass. They're badges of care and life. They call needed attention, too, to the importance of walls: walls, like our skins, can express our smiles, our communications — or our blank psychotic stares.

The B.A.C. mural is being paid for by the National Endowment for the Arts and the National Paint and Coatings Assn., with further help from City Walls and pri-

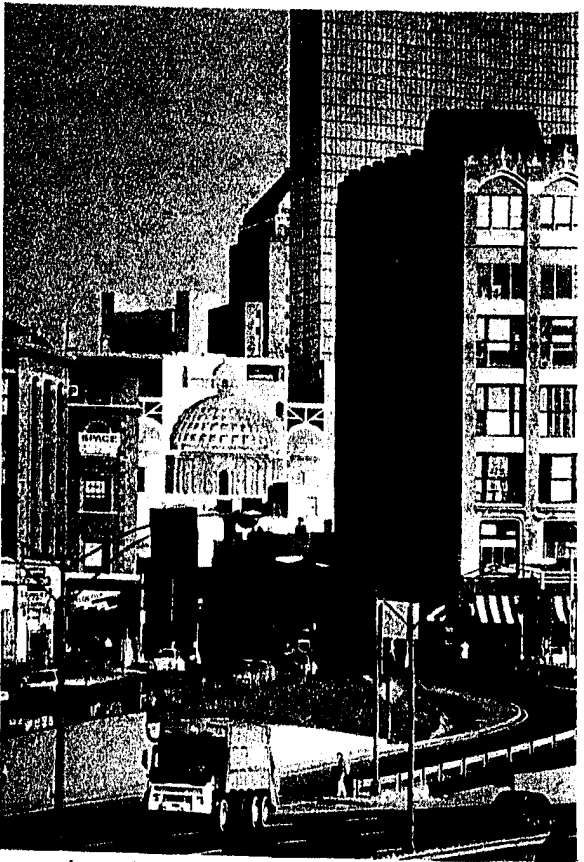
vate donors. Cost problems slowed the work so that it took a year to complete, but it's been done to last — three coats of paint — by Seaboard Advertising of New York and Guayas Gonzales.

The best place to see the mural is from the Massachusetts avenue bridge over the turnpike. If you like what you see, take heart: Dick Haas has a second mural which was just completed at the Hyatt Regency Hotel, where one wall of the hotel's spectacular atrium is now covered with a Venetian Gothic painted balcony. ■



The final plan committed to scale . . .

PHOTOS/MICHAEL MILLER



. . . and completed, viewed from the Mass. Pike.